

Pro Tools offers a host of features ranging from multi track recording, to plug-in support, to the ability to work on a seemingly endless number of tracks (256) and even allows you to easily dub audio, record voices and compose music with the video playing in the same interface.



Steinberg

The next biggest name, often considered to be better than Pro Tools

Niching all the way

is Nuendo. Offering all the capabilities that Pro Tools has, Nuendo is the FCP to Avid's Media Composer. While Nuendo draws parallels with Pro Tools across all lines of comparison, the only two places where Pro Tools sticks its head out is in the number of tracks you can edit- 256 on Pro Tools vs 32 on Nuendo and the price- sort of free/\$699 vs a whopping \$1700. Nuendo also doesn't offer MIDI support but that's for another reason.

Steinberg's other offering is the \$780 Cubase. While Nuendo is intended for post production, Cubase's primary purpose is music composition. Here is where Cubase seems to be sneaking past Pro Tools because not only does it offer an unlimited number of MIDI tracks vs Pro Tool's 512.

Logic

The true FCP to Avid's Media Composer though is Apple's Logic Pro. If you've used Apple's Garage Band, you will find that using Logic will be a breeze because the really cool thing about Logic is that it's brilliant for creating loops, laying down beats (you can substitute this for a drummer) and even lets you compose guitar tracks without any instruments. It does all this while letting you record your own tracks and if you managed to not hit the right notes, you can fix that too.

Because it's made by Apple, it only works on a Mac, but seeing that it only costs \$199, why wouldn't you go for it? When you throw in tons of free downloads- both plug ins and samples, the deal only gets sweeter.

But if you've got almost no budget, then you should spend as much as possible on good quality hardware because the software part of the problem can be very easily worked out.

Audacity

Audacity is an open source audio editor that does everything except do your laundry. It also won't support video, but that's just a minor detail. It works